

Practice Paper 19 — Answer Scheme

Paper 2 — Comprehension

Sections B & C

Note to teachers and students

- Marks are awarded for **meaning**, not for exact words. Where a quotation is required, it has been indicated in inverted commas.
- Where the question asks for **own words**, a candidate who lifts directly from the text receives **zero** for that mark unless the lifted phrase is unavoidable.
- For language and tone questions, accept any reasonable alternative that clearly fits the textual evidence.

Section B — Text 3 Answer Scheme [20 marks]

Q1. [2] — Attitude towards the flowers

1 mark for identifying the narrator's sense that the flowers are **unfamiliar** / **foreign** / **not of her own world**; **1 mark** for identifying her **mild disapproval** or **bemused distance** — they seem over-designed, showy, or trying too hard.

Sample answer: The phrase suggests that the narrator finds the flowers **strange** and **over-elaborate** — they look **cleverly arranged** rather than natural, and she views them with quiet **bemusement**, as though they belong to a world she does not share.

Q2. [2] — “My knees, at eighty-three, no longer rise for occasions”

1 mark each for any two of:

- She is **very old** / **frail** — she is eighty-three and physically limited.
- She is **self-aware** and **gently humorous** about her age — there is wry acceptance in the phrasing.
- She **refuses to pretend** — she will not stand for a ceremony her body cannot meet.
- She is **quietly dignified** — she stays seated without apology or fuss.

Q3. [2] — Granddaughter looking like a stranger

1 mark — Her **perception changes** when her granddaughter turns her face and the narrator recognises **her own mother's jaw** and **her late husband's smile** in it.

1 mark — This suggests the narrator sees **family as continuity** — the people she has loved live on in her granddaughter's features, even when everything else looks foreign.

Q4. [2] — “A procession of small white plates”

1 mark — The word **procession** suggests the food arrives in a **long, formal sequence**, more like a ceremony than a meal, which feels foreign to her.

1 mark — Each plate carries only “a single, careful thing” — a **folded leaf, a circle of fish, a clear soup** — suggesting the food is **carefully designed** and **unfamiliar**, unlike the home cooking she would recognise.

Q5. [1] — “I was somewhere else”

1 mark — It suggests her **mind was not in the room** — she was **lost in memory / thinking of the past / emotionally distant** from the present meal. (Also accept: she was **reflecting on her journey / with her late husband in her thoughts**.)

Q6. [2] — The speeches

(a) [1]: Any **one** of: the speaker **spoke quickly**; the **microphone gave his voice a metallic edge**; her **hearing is not what it was**; her English **prefers slowness**.

(b) [1]: She does so out of **politeness / to fit in / to avoid drawing attention to herself** — she does not want to spoil the occasion or seem out of place, even though she has not understood.

Q7. [2] — “Haltingly, like someone who learned it from a grandmother and not from a country”

1 mark — It suggests her granddaughter learned the language **only from within the family** — from the narrator herself or another relative — rather than by **growing up surrounded by it**.

1 mark — As a result her speech is **uncertain / hesitant / limited in vocabulary**, because she has never lived in a place where everyone speaks it.

Q8. [2] — “Some things one keeps”

1 mark — The narrator is **reserved / private** — she chooses what to share and what to hold back, even from those she loves.

1 mark — It also suggests she has **protected her family from the hardest parts** of her past — she carries her own pain **with quiet dignity** rather than passing it on.

Q9. [2] — Husband’s singing with “no tune at all”

1 mark — It shows that her memory is **honest** and **unsentimental** — she does not falsely improve her husband in recollection.

1 mark — It also shows her **tenderness**: it was not the quality of the singing but the **act of comfort** she remembers and treasures — the tunelessness makes the love **more real**, not less.

Q10. [2] — Contrast in Paragraph 7

1 mark — The **contrast** is between the **youthful, ornamented surface** of her granddaughter’s wedding day (“powder”, “perfume”) and the **quiet ownership** of that day (“hers and not mine”).

1 mark — It suggests the narrator’s **acceptance** — she recognises that the day belongs to a new generation; she is moved, but she does not claim a place at its centre. (Also accept: **bittersweet love / gentle letting go**.)

Q11. [1] — Tone of the final paragraph

1 mark — Any **one** of: **reflective, grateful, fulfilled, bittersweet, quietly triumphant, resolved.** (Reject: **sad, bitter, angry** — these miss the affirming quality.)

Section C — Text 4 Answer Scheme [25 marks]

Q12. [2] — “Gentle, ordinary, and almost entirely unnoticed”

1 mark — Adults do not stop reading **dramatically** or **deliberately**; they drift away from novels **gradually** and **without any clear decision**.

1 mark — The change is **common** / **unremarkable** / **part of ordinary adult life**, which is why no one — including the readers themselves — really registers that it has happened.

Q13. [2] — Evidence of decline

1 mark each for any two of:

- The **National Literacy Trust** reports that the proportion of UK adults reading fiction for pleasure has **fallen by more than ten percentage points** in the past decade.
- A **2022 Pew survey** found that **almost a quarter** of American adults had **not finished a single novel** in the previous year.
- The anecdotal image of a **paperback still bookmarked on page forty-three**, the bookmark **gathering dust**.

Q14. [2] — “Shaped to fragments of two minutes”

1 mark — A working day spent answering messages and notifications has trained the adult mind to operate in **very short bursts of attention** / **to switch tasks every couple of minutes**.

1 mark — This is a problem because the novel demands the **opposite** — long, **uninterrupted** periods of concentration that the fragmented mind can no longer easily sustain.

Q15. [2] — “In competition with the entire structure of an adult week”

1 mark — The novel is not only fighting against **one rival** (the phone); it must compete with **every demand** of adult life.

1 mark — These demands include **work, family, household tasks** and **social obligations** — taken together, they leave almost no empty hours of the kind that reading a novel requires.

Q16. [1] — Italics on **useful**

1 mark — The italics give the word **emphasis**; the writer is signalling that **usefulness** has become the **defining criterion** by which adults now judge a book — and that this is a **significant shift** worth pausing on. (Also accept: it carries a **slightly critical** / **ironic** tone, since the writer goes on to suggest fiction was never meant to be useful.)

Q17. [2] — Fiction has “refused” usefulness

1 mark — **Refused** is a strong, almost stubborn word — fiction has **deliberately set itself apart** from any practical purpose.

1 mark — It suggests that the **value** of fiction lies elsewhere — in **feeling, imagination, or experience** — and that judging novels by usefulness misses the point of what they are for.

Q18. [2] — Emory University findings (own words)

1 mark — Regular novel readers showed **stronger connections** in the **parts of the brain** responsible for **understanding other people’s feelings**.

1 mark — They were also better at **imagining the inner lives of others** — at **picturing what it is like to be someone else**.

Reject answers that lift “increased connectivity” or “mental simulation of other lives” without rewording.

Q19. [1] — Effect of **sanctioned**

1 mark — **Sanctioned** suggests the reading hour is **permitted** / **officially allowed** — fiction grants the reader **legitimate permission** to feel things that the busy working day usually leaves no room for.

Q20. [2] — Waiting that novels require

1 mark each for any two of:

- Waiting **for a sentence to land** / for its full meaning to arrive.
- Waiting **for a character to change** over time.
- Waiting **for a meaning to emerge from a hundred quiet pages**.
- The capacity to **dwell with a long, slow thing** — a symphony, a marriage, a book.

Q21. [2] — Tone of the final sentence

1 mark — **Reflective** / **gently challenging** / **quietly thoughtful**.

1 mark — It also carries a note of **hope** / **invitation** — the writer is not scolding the reader but asking, kindly, whether the choice to “be slow” is still within reach. (Reject: **angry**, **despairing**, **cynical**.)

Q22. Summary [13 marks total: 6 content + 7 style]

Content points (½ mark each, max 6 marks). **Eight available content points; candidates should aim for all 8.**

Why adults stop reading novels (Paragraphs 2–4):

1. The **smartphone** dominates daily life — adults spend several hours each day on phones and screens.
2. Such use **fragments attention** — the mind grows used to short bursts and struggles with long ones.
3. Adult life is **busy** in a way adolescence is not — work, mortgage, children, parents, and household duties leave few free hours.
4. Adults increasingly turn to **non-fiction** / self-help / “useful” reading to **learn** rather than to **feel**.

What is lost when they stop (Paragraphs 5–6):

5. A cognitive loss — reduced **empathy** and a weaker ability to **imagine other people’s lives**.
6. An emotional loss — fewer **quiet, permitted hours** in which to feel grief, longing or tenderness.
7. A loss of **patience** / capacity for slowness — the ability to wait for meaning to emerge.
8. A wider decline in **sustained attention**, which makes long, slow experiences (a symphony, a marriage, a book) harder to enjoy.

Sample full-marks summary (78 words):

Many adults stop reading novels because phones and screens dominate their hours and train the mind to work only in short bursts. Adult life — jobs, children, parents, chores — leaves few free stretches, and what reading remains is largely “useful” non-fiction. The losses are real: reduced empathy and imagination, fewer permitted hours for quiet feeling, and a steady decline in patience, so that long, slow experiences such as a symphony, a marriage or a book become harder to enjoy.

Length count: 78 words from “Many” onwards.

— END OF ANSWER SCHEME —